

Practical guide:

3 keys to overcoming the main challenges faced by CIOs



The pandemic is already becoming a distant memory for many of us.

However, the accelerated adoption of new technologies it triggered in organizations globally – in the wake of the quarantine and the need to work remotely – entered a new phase in 2023.

In addition to the accelerated adoption of technology, there is a need to face the challenging and volatile economic context successfully.

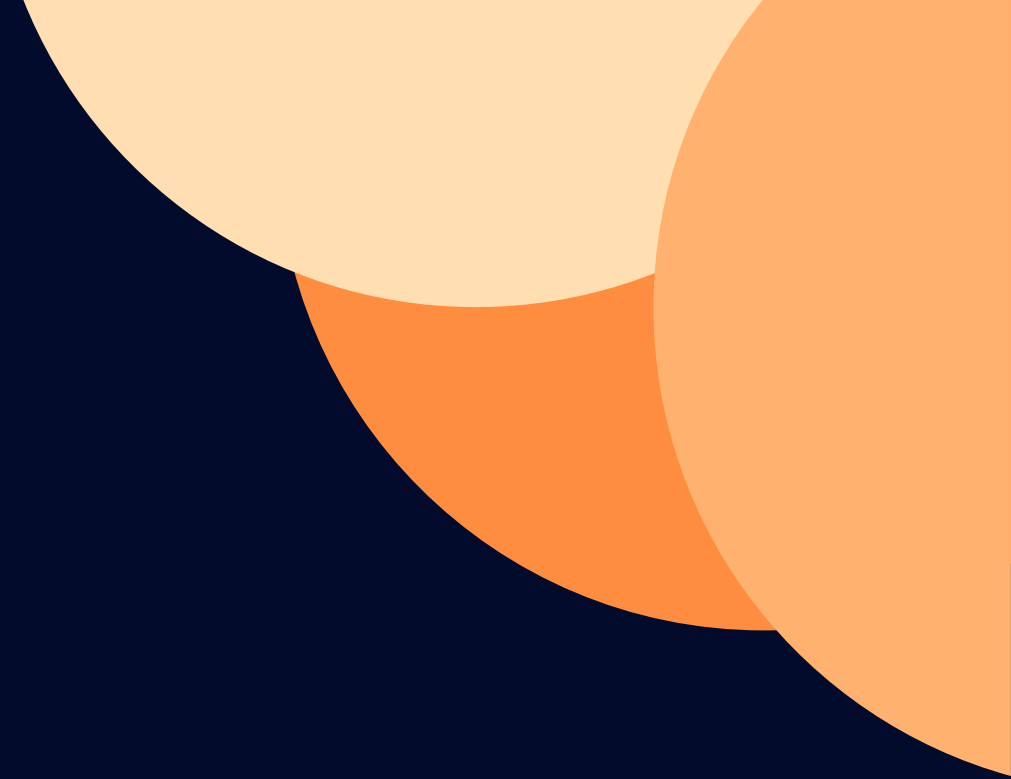
Facing this context is one of the biggest challenges for those who want to boost the performance of their organizations through technology.

However, how can a CIO drive organizational development through technology in these complex contexts?

The options range from prioritizing digital initiatives to improving the employee experience (and the customer experience).

Building a culture of organizational resilience driven by IT management and development complements all this.

Ultimately, these will be the foundations that will support the ability to respond to unexpected situations that threaten business continuity in any organization.



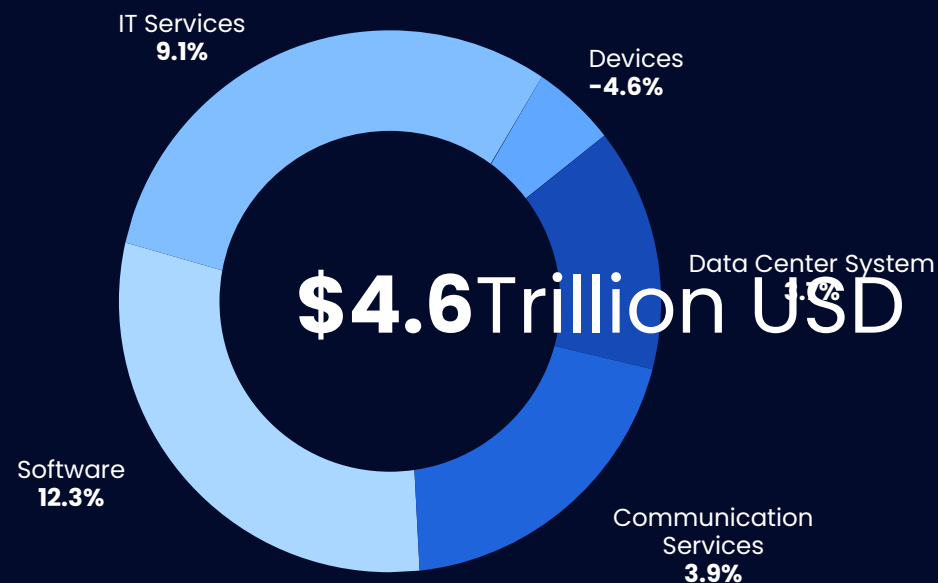
Challenge 1

Accelerate digital initiatives in times of uncertainty

Times of economic instability could make us think that investments are not on the list of priorities for companies.

However, this is not true. To adapt quickly and remain competitive, organizations must invest in digital initiatives.

Global IT Spending and Growth for 2023

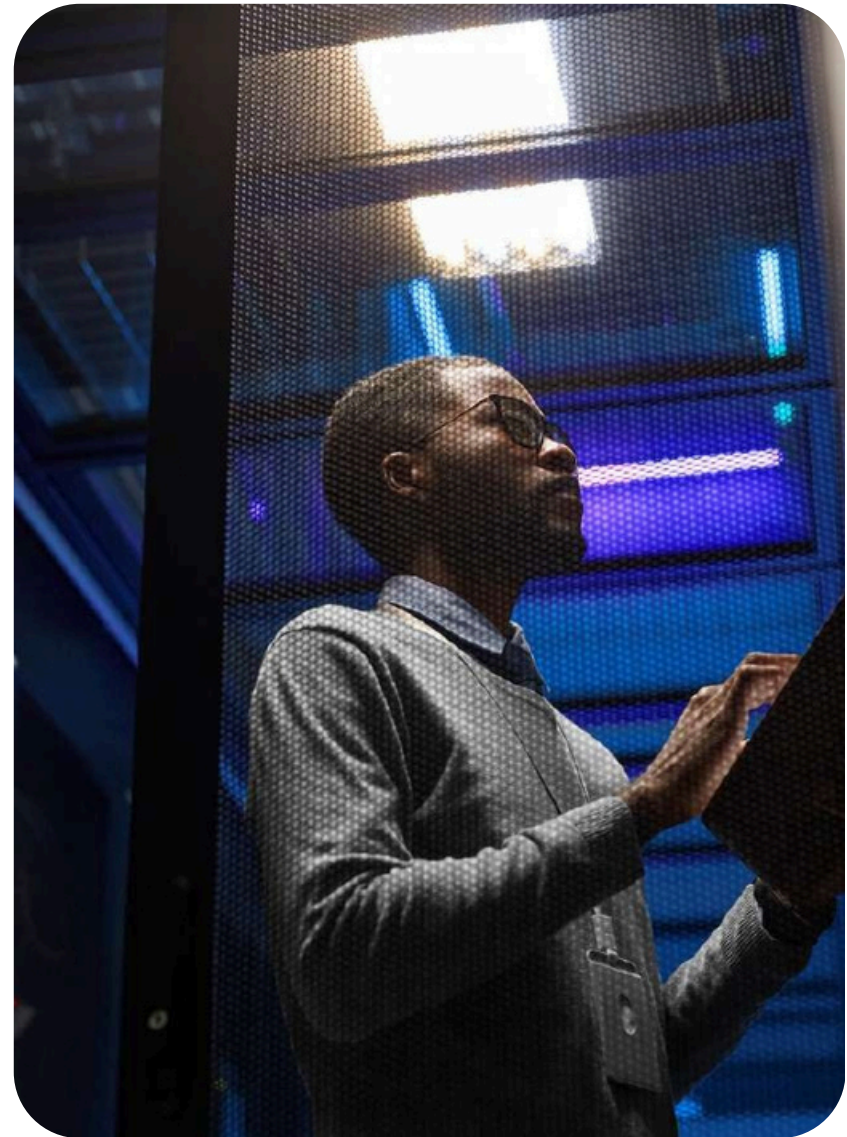


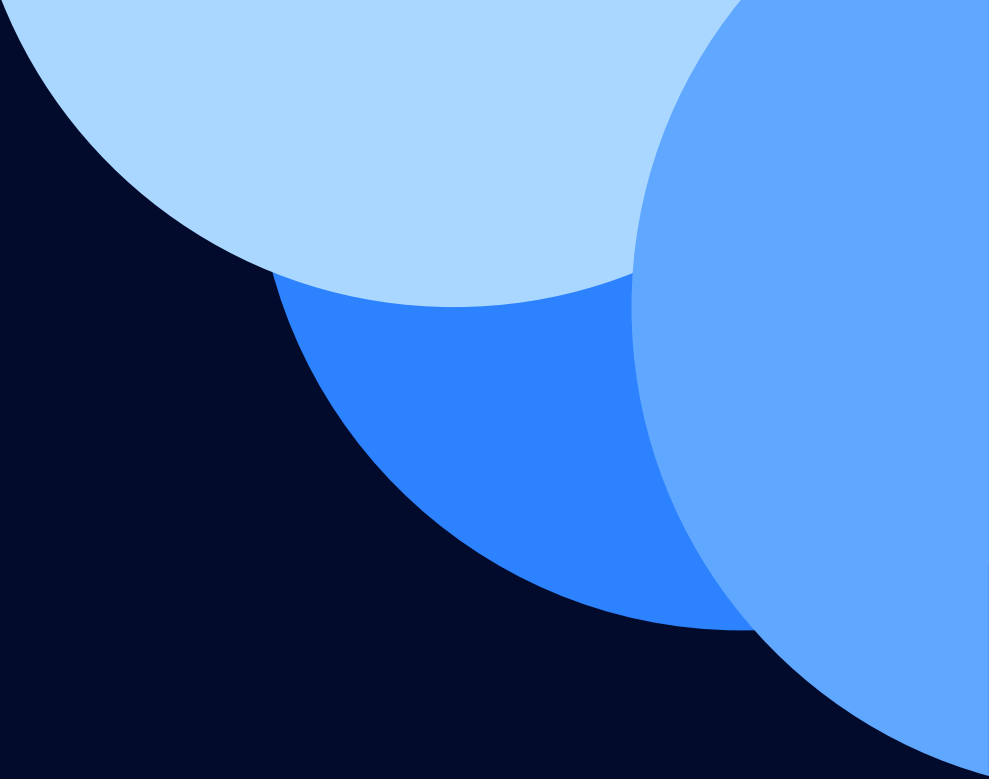
Source: *Gartner Market Databook, April 2023.*

Organizations should look for ways to rely on technology to grow and compensate for economic bottlenecks and the possible hardships of their respective niches.

Whatever the size of the investment, it must be considered a priority.

Now, how can an organization meet the challenge of investing in IT to continue growing when the economic context calls for them to cut or maintain operational expenses?





Key 1

Accelerate digital initiatives

Among the many initiatives that can address this, we can highlight:

1. Eliminating legacy systems

To make the digital initiative from IT viable in times of economic uncertainty, the current systems in use must be thoroughly evaluated.

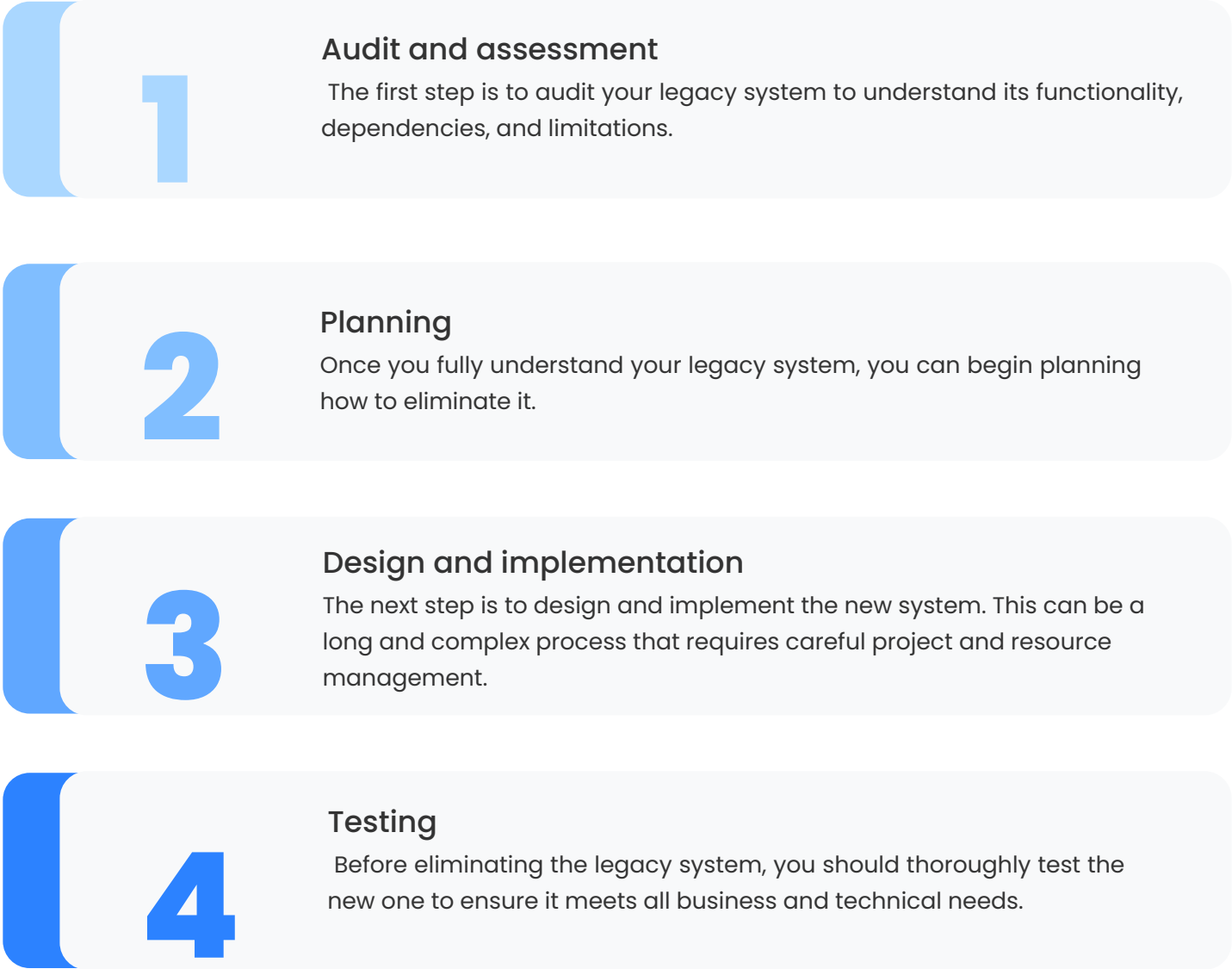
Outdated systems that comprise software solutions, computer systems, or applications still in use are known as legacy systems and should be eliminated or updated.

The reasons for maintaining a legacy system can vary:

- Lack of integration of the data used in a new one.
- Poor U/X forces employees to continue using the old.
- Poor management.

What happens when you don't remove a legacy system or do not accomplish a proper transition to new systems? The team will be obliged to maintain two systems, incurring in significant expenditures. In these times of economic instability, no company can afford this.

However, phasing out legacy systems must be done step by step because it is a complex process that requires careful planning. Some of the steps to accomplish this are:



1

Audit and assessment

The first step is to audit your legacy system to understand its functionality, dependencies, and limitations.

2

Planning

Once you fully understand your legacy system, you can begin planning how to eliminate it.

3

Design and implementation

The next step is to design and implement the new system. This can be a long and complex process that requires careful project and resource management.

4

Testing

Before eliminating the legacy system, you should thoroughly test the new one to ensure it meets all business and technical needs.



5

Data migration

Migrating the old data to the new system can be challenging, especially when having large amounts of data or if the data is in an old or unusual format.



6

Transition

Once the new system is in place, you can begin transitioning to disuse the old one gradually to minimize disruption.



7

Decommissioning

Once the new system is fully operational and all users have been transferred, you can decommission the old system.

2. Align IT with business objectives and needs

Technology alone does not represent any improvement for the organization that takes advantage of it.

Digital efforts must answer to business demands so economic performance meets the functional enhancement technology promises.

To help identify whether the digital initiative aligns with what the company needs from a business perspective, you can ask yourself the following questions:

- How do our IT solutions integrate with the company's existing processes and systems?
- Will it help ensure business continuity during catastrophic events?

- Will it improve processes directly related to the organization's financial profit generation?
- Improve employee experience and productivity?
- Improve customer experience and help build customer loyalty.

By supporting business objectives and implementing efficient and agile information technology (IT), you can optimize operational performance, increase productivity and, in the long run, generate greater financial returns for the organization.

3. Cultivate a healthy organizational culture

Committed employees to the company's values and objectives are less keen to let external factors affect their perception of the company or their performance.

Employees who feel connected to the culture of their organizations are **4.9 times more likely to agree** that their organizations have the speed and agility to meet changing customer expectations and changes in markets and industries.

– *Source: – Gallup, To Drive Customer Retention, Don't Neglect Culture, 2023.*

How do you achieve this healthy organizational culture? By improving communication and collaboration across teams and areas.

You should also need efficient processes, fewer manual tasks, and learning and innovation spaces.

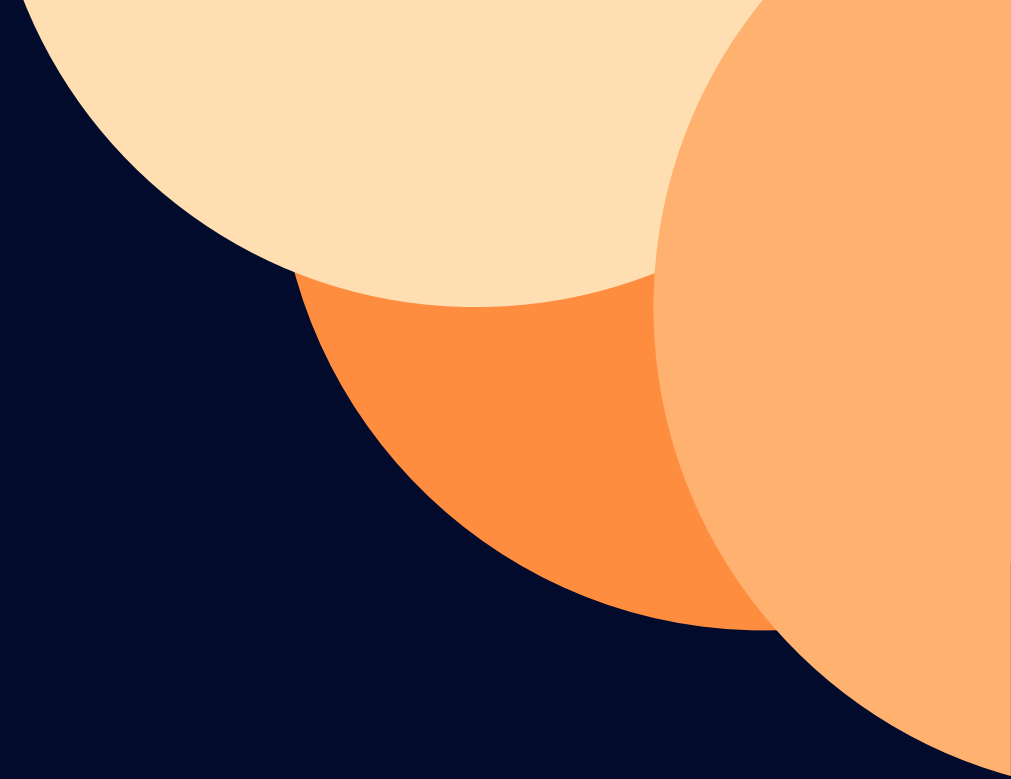
As a result, your employees will be less likely to fall into the dreaded burnout or even resign.

4. Promote sustainable initiatives

Whatever the nature of what you want to develop, you must ensure it is sustainable over time. Sustainability ensures the company can generate enough revenue to cover its costs and make profits.

In that regard, you should strive to optimize and receive the return on investment (ROI) of each project in the shortest time feasible.





Challenge 2

Having satisfied and committed employees

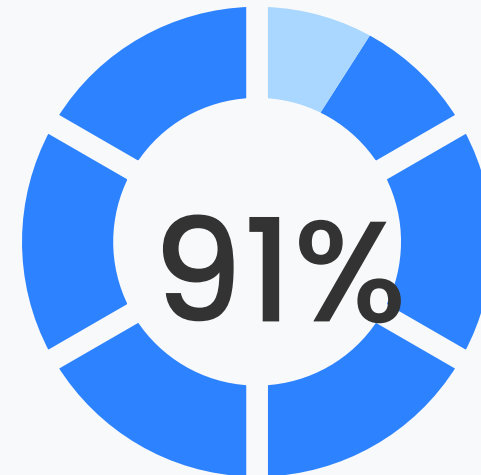
The pandemic accelerated the adoption of new technologies in organizations to face challenges such as remote work or the move of many dynamics to the digital environment.

With this, the global IT area acquired a bigger scale and importance for business continuity, employee, and customer experience.

For this reason, we insist on the importance of alignment between IT and the commercial side of the business. IT leaders must not only consider the employee experience within IT teams. They need to also consider the experience of those in the rest of the organization's teams.

This will ultimately define the quality of the organization's products or services.

When employees have access to technology that supports their work and boosts their productivity, they have an engagement rate of



Source: Qualtrics, Employee Experience Trends Report for 2022.

This is why we must rely on IT and digital initiatives in organizations to improve employee experiences.

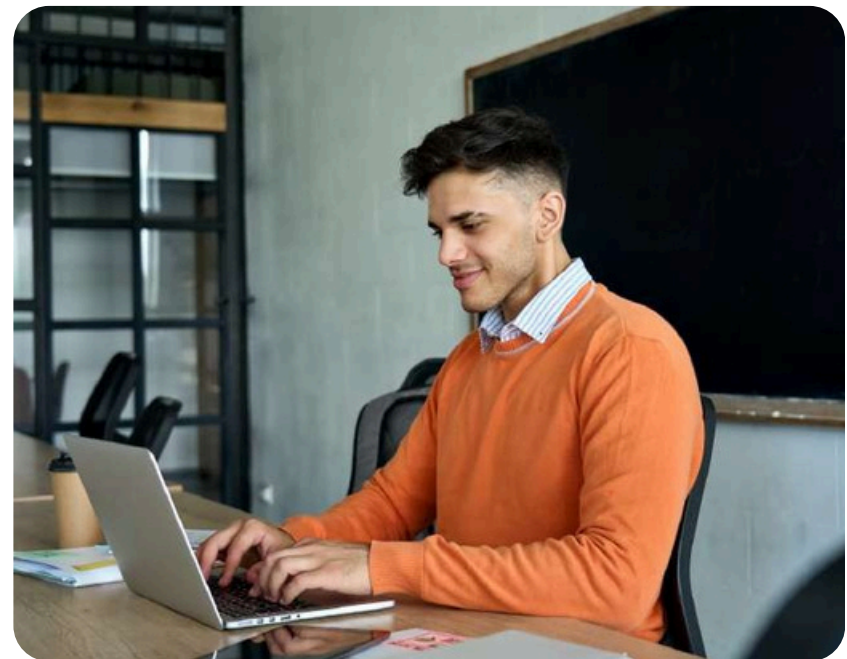
These experiences must be devoid of manual and repetitive tasks. The focus is to automate processes and offer intuitive tools to lighten workloads on teams, allowing them to focus on more strategic and impactful tasks in the business.

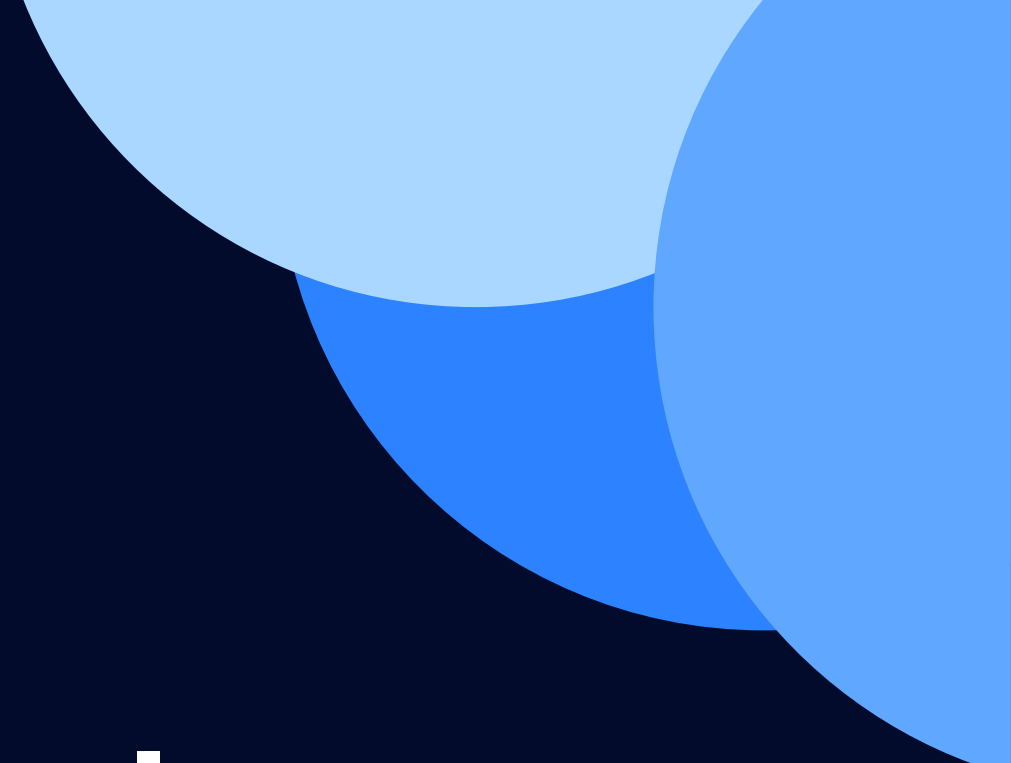
You can achieve this by promoting collaboration between teams and areas within the organization through virtual collaboration tools and by providing better training and support to managers.

Ultimately, it all comes down to having robust leaders- hip, clear expectations, great teamwork, and constant improvement of each employee's work development.

Those organizations that ride this wave and put their employees as a priority are the ones that will be able to outperform competitors that do not follow this path in the short and medium term.

This short- and medium-term advantage is essential during periods of economic uncertainty.





Key 2

**Improve the employee
experience to drive
team performance**

1. Facilitate IT collaboration with the rest of the business

How can you facilitate this collaboration?

You may begin by encouraging open communication. Clear and cross-departmental communication channels are essential to allow information exchange across individuals and areas.

In addition, define common goals between IT and the rest of the organization.

Today, the employee experience is determined by how easily they interact with the technologies used in their areas.

When IT collaborates with other departments, it may better understand their needs and build solutions that solve real-world issues like bottlenecks in different areas' workflow.

For this reason, all efforts and initiatives related to technology must go hand in hand with improving performance, facilitating processes, and enhancing organizational performance.

In addition, this collaboration can lead to more innovation. Having a deep understanding of the challenges and goals of different departments allows IT to propose new technologies or approaches that could give the business a competitive advantage.

It is critical to establish open and frequent communication between IT and other departments to support this collaboration. Regular meetings, specialized communication channels, and the engagement of IT personnel in strategic decision-making might all be part of this.

2. Use user-friendly technologies

In this regard, we must consider users from all areas of the organization.

As far as IT is concerned, using low-code tools can be a differentiator that allows building applications needed quickly and without heavy coding behind it. This also enables IT agents with less knowledge to participate in developing digital solutions required inside the organization.

However, whether the digital solution is licensed or in-house, the end user needs to be considered in its development.

As a result, it is critical to remember the preceding point: IT and the rest of the company should collaborate closely. This is the only way to have processes with realistic learning curves for teams.

What aspects of this collaboration should be covered?



Planning the implementation



Implementation execution



Configuration



Training the people who will be the end users

This will ensure that each team gets the most out of the tool and that the organization achieves successful results.

3. Prioritize employee well-being

Promoting employee wellness is relevant for several reasons. First, physically, mentally, and emotionally healthy employees tend to be more productive and effective at work.

In addition, employees who feel valued and cared for are more likely to stay with the company, which can reduce turnover costs.

And what role does technology play in all of this?

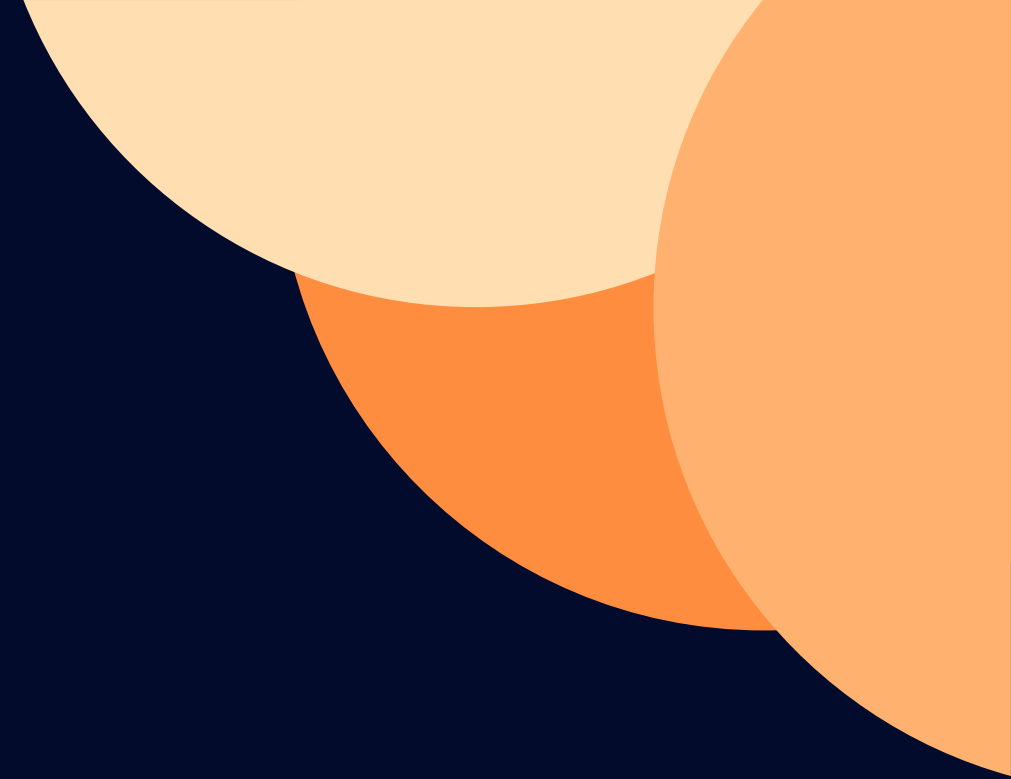
These initiatives affect in how employees perceive their experience and the company. Let's see:

- Productivity and time management apps can help employees organize their work, set priorities and stay focused.

- Technology can automate repetitive and tedious tasks, freeing time for employees to focus on more creative and meaningful work.

- Data management systems and online search platforms make it easier for employees to find the information they need to do their jobs.

In short, technology can make work less stressful and more rewarding by simplifying and streamlining many aspects of daily operations.



Challenge 3

Building Resilience

Uncertain times highlight the importance of resilience within an organization. Employee performance and business continuity can be affected if the organization does not actively prepare for every possible eventuality.

How do uncertainty and instability affect employees?

What are the factors that, from an IT perspective, affect the resilience of organizations?

Inefficient communication

Inadequate infrastructure

Lack of talent

Outdated and inflexible processes

Resistance to change

Lack of agility

According to Gallup, 38% of employees say they are confident about the financial future of their organizations.

IT can help build resilience to improve business performance and employee experience. As a result, the organization can ensure performance in adverse contexts (an essential aspect of success in such contexts).



Key 3

Build a resilient culture from within IT

1. Focus on Business Continuity

IT can actively support business continuity management to arm itself against any unexpected event.

How can you do this? By creating a business continuity plan that includes the critical aspects of your business and relying on software tools that bring everything to the digital plane.



Key Business Continuity Principles



Responsibility

Organizational directors and managers have primary responsibility for business continuity within the organization.



Clear objectives

To choose the right resource management priorities, the organization must set clear objectives for the business continuity efforts it intends to undertake.



Impact and Risk Assessment

Through a risk analysis phase, it is possible to know and assess which risks need to be considered and their particular impact on the organization.



Communication

To maximize the success of all efforts, the company must make communication its primary instrument, beginning with the directors and managers, for communicating the information and actions to be taken from the continuity plans to employees in all parts of the organization.



Test

The plan and the solutions implemented must be constantly tested, evaluated, and updated to maintain the margin of effectiveness of the continuity initiatives. Also, automating the workflows associated with this continuity management helps save time and resources. It also helps ensure the efficiency and effectiveness of the related processes.

2. Lean on flexibility

One of the greatest assets in times of uncertainty is flexibility and the ability to adapt to new contexts.

As a result, IT-enabled agility is critical to maintaining business performance.

- Ensure fluid communication and collaboration with the right tools.
- Empower the operation of specific areas with platforms built with low code and tailored to needs.
- Automate entire processes and workflows in any area that needs it.

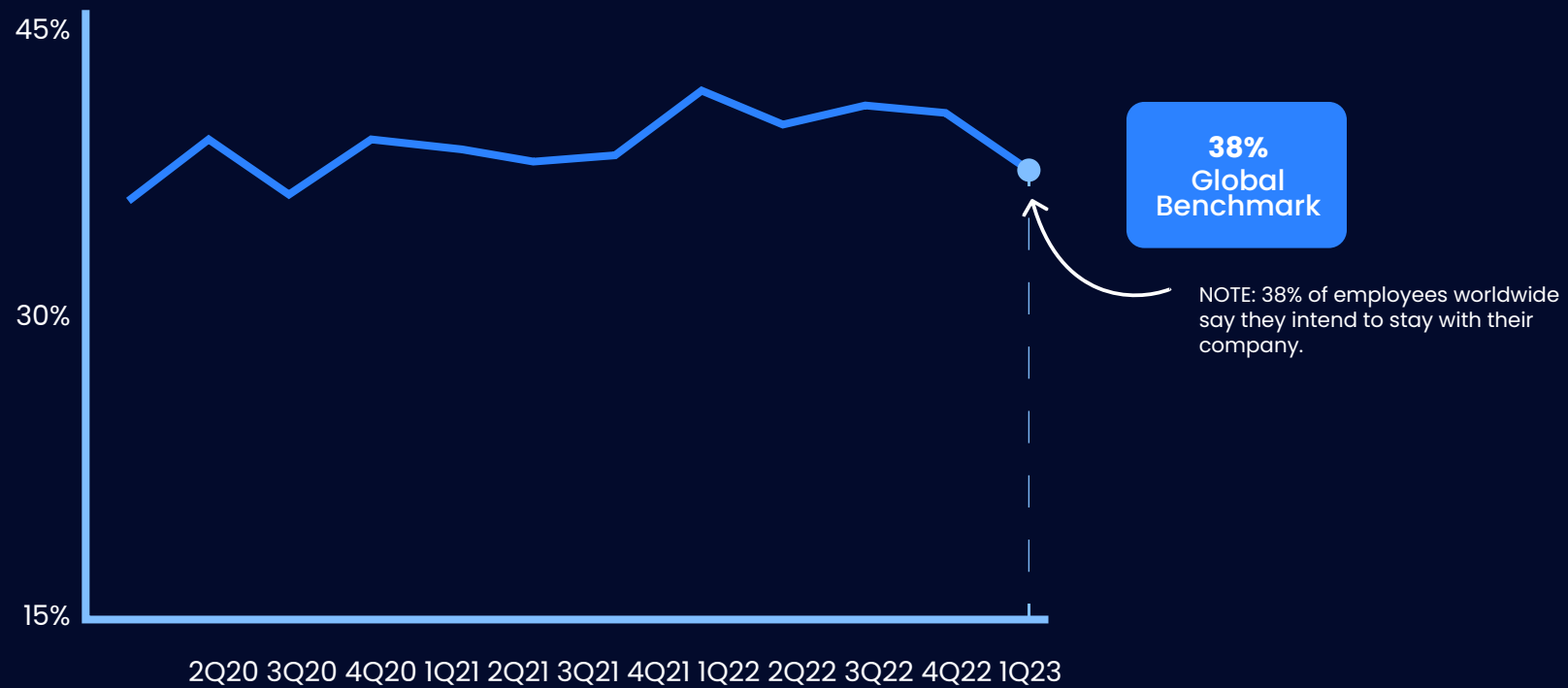
All of this will give the company the flexibility to face challenges such as the return to the office, hybrid work, or complex economic contexts.

3. Manage well the talent you already have

This is essential to cultivate a culture of resilience and rootedness in the organization.

Intent to Stay (1Q2023)

Percentage of Employees



Source: Gartner, *Focusing on Talent Retention to Grow Your Organization*, 2023.

How can you do this? You can start:

- Prioritize visibility and process transparency.
- Optimizing processes and infrastructure (software) that may be outdated.
- Clearly define roles and responsibilities.
- Eliminate information silos.
- Provide opportunities for professional growth and development.

Involve your employees in decision-making and defining the company's goals and strategies.

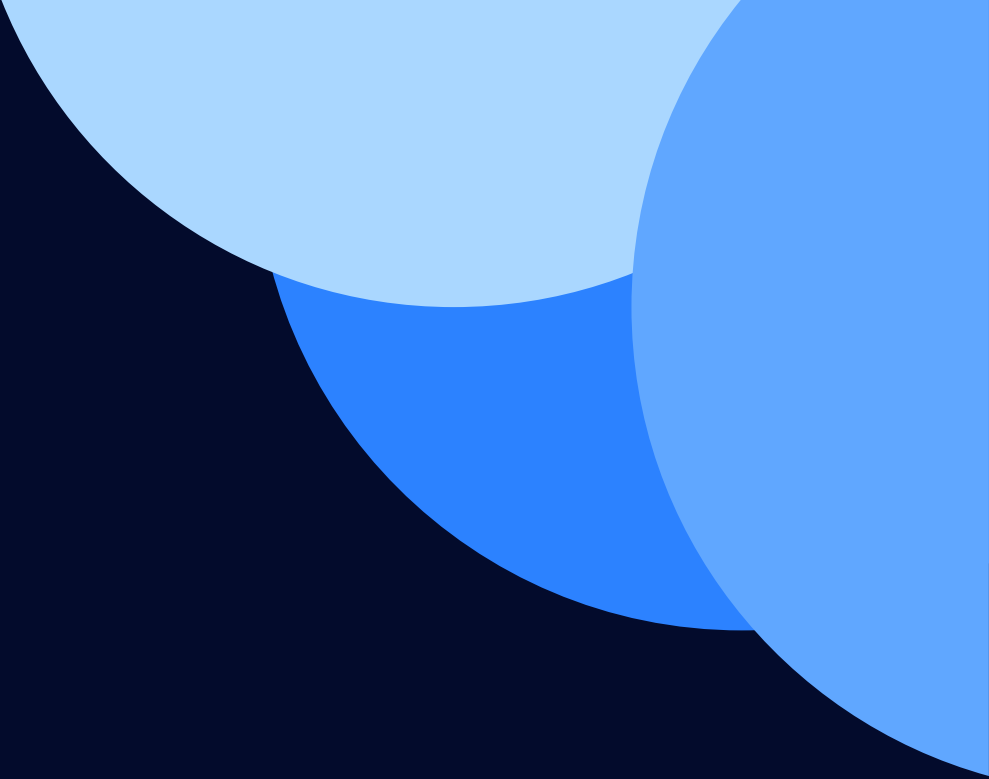
Considering these points helps you create an environment where employees feel comfortable and can adapt to any work mode, whether fully remote or hybrid.

Your talent will be empowered by technology while working through processes that minimize errors and ensure efficiency, with clear roles and objectives that allow them to focus on adding value.

As a result, you can avoid the costs associated with high employee turnover (recruiting, interviewing, onboarding, and training).

You will also have employees who are more engaged in the organization's culture, have a greater sense of well-being, and are ultimately happier and more engaged.

This will motivate them to continue to give their best to the organization.



Conclusion

In conclusion, we have identified the key challenges CIOs face in leading organizations through periods of uncertainty.

We must address these challenges and take the necessary steps to overcome them to ensure successful management and adaptability in an ever-changing business environment.

Concerning the technology portion of these recommendations, if you are considering new technology solutions to provide your organization with greater efficiency, control, and productivity, we recommend that you consider

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This low-code tool helps large enterprises increase productivity and efficiency through solutions focused on:

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With ServiceNow, your organization will gain:



Adaptability

With its low-code platform, ServiceNow enables organizations to create customized solutions to address new challenges.



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In summary, ServiceNow gives CIOs the flexibility, efficiency, visibility, security, and scalability they need to meet any challenge.

If your goal is to strengthen your IT department and need help integrating new technologies and processes, contact us. We are ready to show you the way to a more resilient organization.

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